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YOU ARE NOT DIFFICULT. YOU ARE UNHEARD.

On women, men, and the love
no one taught us



YOU ARE NOT DIFFICULT. YOU ARE UNHEARD.

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INTRODUCTION

For years, we were told that love should simply happen. That when we met the right man, everything would be easy. That if he truly loved us, he would know what we needed. That if we truly loved him, we should sacrifice ourselves without end.

But life looks different. We meet. We fall in love. We are disappointed. Sometimes we cry because of someone who does not even know we are hurting. Sometimes we leave people we love. Sometimes we stay too long.

This book is not about finding the perfect man, because perfect people do not exist. It is about understanding yourself. Understanding men. And learning to stop fighting one another.

The truth is that most women do not want a fairy-tale prince. They want a human being—someone beside whom they can be themselves, cuddle after a hard day, talk, feel safe, and feel no need to pretend. Most men want exactly the same thing.

Yet for years we have learned to see one another through our own assumptions. We have our ideas about men; they have theirs about women. Very often, both sides are convinced they know what the other wants. Perhaps we should simply begin talking—to each other—about needs, emotions, intimacy, sex, safety, and what is missing.

Maybe the problem is not that women are too difficult or that men are too closed off. Maybe no one ever taught us how to truly talk to one another. That is what this book is about.

A woman with dark hair tied back, wearing a dark, heavy coat, is walking away from the viewer. She is carrying a large, open suitcase in front of her. The suitcase is filled with numerous old, sepia-toned photographs of people. The background is a soft, hazy landscape with mountains and a body of water.

PART I

BEFORE WE BEGIN TO UNDERSTAND EACH OTHER

Every relationship begins long before another person appears. It begins within us: in what our parents taught us, in a first love, a first disappointment, and the way we learned to respond to closeness and rejection. That is why a new relationship does not always contain only two people. Two pasts enter it as well.

CHAPTER 1

Every Woman Carries Her Own Story



Every Woman Carries Her Own Story

When we see a woman sitting alone in a café, we see only a woman. We do not see her past. We do not know how many times she began again, how many nights she cried, or how many people she had to support while she herself needed support.

Every woman carries a story. Sometimes it shows in her eyes. Sometimes it cannot be seen at all.

For years, Anna was “the strong one.” Everyone at work could rely on her. At home, too. If somebody needed help, they called her. If somebody had a problem, she listened. If somebody cried, she held them. But nobody asked, “And who holds you?”

One evening she returned to an empty apartment, sat on the sofa, and—for the first time in a long while—allowed herself to cry. Nothing dramatic had happened. She was simply tired. Tired of being strong.

The next day somebody said, “You always manage.” She smiled, but this time she thought, “Maybe that is exactly why no one notices that sometimes I do not want to manage alone.”

Asking for help does not take away your strength. It allows another person to come close. Intimacy begins when we stop pretending that everything is fine.

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Perhaps this is why we miss one another so often in relationships. She waits for someone to notice. He waits for her to say something. She thinks that if she has to ask, the gesture will no longer be genuine. He thinks that if she said nothing, everything must be all right. Both may suffer, although neither intended to hurt the other.

Before moving on, pause with this thought: every woman carries something that cannot be seen at first. Sometimes the greatest problem is not that no one understands us, but that we have tried to be brave and silent for too long. The next story begins with a sentence women say very often: “I’m fine.”

CHAPTER 2

The Woman Who Always Said, “I’m Fine”



The Woman Who Always Said, “I’m Fine”

“What’s wrong?”
“Nothing.”
“Are you sure?”
“Yes.”

She said “nothing” so convincingly that he could believe her. Yet she wanted him not to. She wanted him to ask once more, put down his phone, and hold her.

Magda had had a difficult day. She did not want to explain everything; she only wanted someone near. He asked, “Is everything all right?”

"I'm fine."

He returned to what he was doing. An hour later, she exploded. "You never notice anything!"

He looked surprised. "But you said everything was all right."

"You should have known!"

For the first time, she saw that he truly had not known. He was not pretending or ignoring her. He had simply believed what she said.

The next day she told him, "Yesterday, I needed a hug."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"I wanted you to know on your own."

"I can't read minds. But I can learn to listen to you."

That was enough. Perhaps love is not about the other person always knowing. Perhaps it is about being able to tell them.

• • •

We do not have to know how to express every need immediately. Sometimes we learn only after many years. But it is worth trying, because an unspoken need gives the other person no chance to meet it.

When we learn to say "I'm fine," we also learn to hide our needs. Later, we resent the other person for failing to see them. The next story is about a woman who expected a man to work everything out for himself.

CHAPTER 3

Sometimes He Leaves One Woman Only to Leave the Next



Sometimes He Leaves One Woman Only to Leave the Next

Marta did not want to be “the other woman.” When she met him, he was still in a relationship. He said, “It ended long ago. There is no intimacy between us. I have wanted to leave for ages.”

Marta listened and began to believe their meeting was destiny. Eventually, he left—for her, or so she thought. The first months were beautiful: intense emotions, constant messages, endless plans.

Then something changed. His phone increasingly lay face down. New women appeared. Flirting. Messages. More explanations.

Marta began to understand what she had refused to see: a person can change partners without changing himself.

Not every such story must end badly. People have the right to separate and fall in love again. But watch how a person behaves. Does he accept responsibility? Can he say, “I made mistakes too”? Are all his former partners supposedly to blame? Does he finish one relationship before beginning another?

Marta did not want to become the next woman in the same story. She left—not because she had stopped feeling, but because she had begun to respect herself more.

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Not every new love is a mistake, but a new woman should not become therapy for an old life. If a person has not worked through his patterns, he may carry them into the next relationship. Do not look only at whom he left for. Look at who he is once he stays with you.

Sometimes what hurts most is not that someone left, but that for a long time we lived in a silence no one tried to break. The next story is about a home where two people still lived together but shared less and less of a life.

CHAPTER 4

I Waited for Him to Work It Out



I Waited for Him to Work It Out

For a long time, I believed that if someone truly cared, he would know when I was sad, when I needed touch, when I wanted conversation, and when I needed silence.

Marta came home after a hard day wanting only one thing: a hug. Her partner asked, “How was your day?”

“Fine.”

It was not fine, but she said nothing. She waited. An hour passed. At last, she burst out: “You don’t see anything at all!”

“What was I supposed to see?”

“That I’m hurting!”

“How was I supposed to know?”

She fell silent. Suddenly she understood that he genuinely had not known—not because he did not love her, but because she had said nothing.

The next day she explained, “When I’m sad, I do not always need a solution. Sometimes I want you to hold me.”

“All right,” he replied. “But sometimes you have to tell me.”

It was not romantic. It was real. Real intimacy is like that. It is not telepathy. It is conversation.

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Perhaps we should stop testing love—stop checking whether someone will guess, punishing with silence, and expecting another person to decipher a code we never showed them. Sometimes the bravest sentence in a relationship is: “This is what I need right now.”

When we stop talking, a relationship does not always collapse immediately. Sometimes it simply grows quiet until silence becomes normal. Then the question appears: am I more afraid of being alone, or of living beside someone and feeling alone?

CHAPTER 5

When Silence Moved Into the House



When Silence Moved Into the House

At first, silence was convenient. After an argument, each returned to a separate life. She left for work. He came home late. In the evening, they sat beside each other while the television, their phones, and everyday duties spoke for them. Only they had stopped talking.

Once, they could talk until two in the morning—about dreams, sex, and the future. Then came bills, work, children, exhaustion, and problems. Suddenly, they knew each other's schedules but no longer knew each other's thoughts.

One evening she asked, "Do you remember the last time we truly talked?"

He was silent for a long time. "No."

At that moment, they both understood that they had not stopped loving each other. They had stopped meeting emotionally.

A relationship does not always end with betrayal or a terrible argument. Sometimes it ends very quietly: with one unspoken sentence, then another, until one day two people sit side by side and no longer know what to say.

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Do not wait until silence becomes more comfortable than conversation. Ask: “How do you really feel? What are you missing? Are you happy?” We may not hear the answer we want, but at least we will hear the truth.

Loneliness so often keeps us in relationships that stopped being good long ago. Loneliness does not always mean an empty home. Sometimes it means an empty place beside the person who should be closest.

CHAPTER 6

What I Feared Most Was Loneliness



What I Feared Most Was Loneliness

I feared loneliness more than a bad relationship. It took me many years to admit this. It is easy to say, “I know what I want.” It is harder to say, “I am afraid that if I leave, I will be alone.”

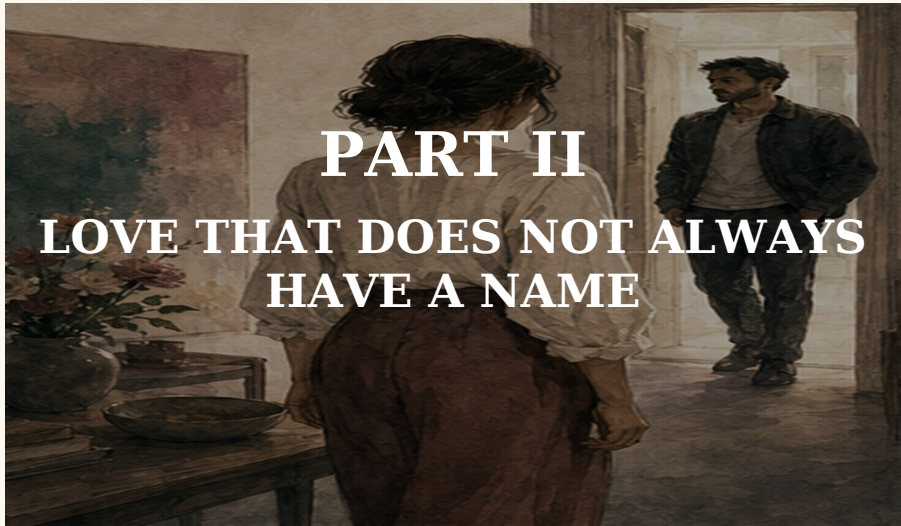
That is why I accepted things I did not want for so long: uncertainty, waiting, undefined relationships, and men who returned whenever it suited them. Even a few hours of closeness seemed better than an empty evening.

Only later did I understand that loneliness and being alone are not the same. You can be alone and feel peaceful. You can sleep beside someone and feel an enormous emptiness. Loneliness does not always begin when someone leaves.

Sometimes it begins when we stop being ourselves so that someone will stay.

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When you stop fearing the empty place beside you, you begin to see returning people differently. Not every return is a decision. Sometimes it is merely longing—or a test to see whether the door is still open.



Not every relationship has a name. Not every one has a beginning we can point to, or ends with a single sentence. Sometimes it consists of months of messages. Sometimes a few meetings. Sometimes one night. And sometimes someone returns only to remind us how deeply we missed him.

CHAPTER 7

He Always Returned When She Began to Forget



He Always Returned When She Began to Forget

He always appeared at exactly the right moment—just as she was regaining her peace, no longer checking her phone, and, for the first time in ages, not thinking about him before sleep.

Then came: “Hey. How are you?” One message, and everything returned.

They met. It was beautiful: tenderness, flirting, touch, emotion. Then he disappeared again, leaving her with the question, “What did I do wrong?”

One day, a friend said, “Maybe you are asking the wrong person.”

“What do you mean?”

“Do not ask why he comes back. Ask why he never stays.”

That changed everything. A return is not proof of love. The decision to stay is something entirely different.

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Some people return because they miss you. Some because they are lonely. Some because they like knowing the door is still open. You do not have to open it for every return.

BETWEEN CHAPTERS

BLOCK HIM. YOU MUST STOP WAITING

“Block him.”

She looked at her friend as though she had suggested the impossible. “What?”

“Block him. Everywhere.”

“I can’t.”

“Why?”

What could she say? That she feared he would never write again? That she wanted to see whether he was online? That she checked his profile despite promising herself she would stop? That when the phone was silent, she wondered whether he might be thinking about her?

“Because maybe he’ll contact me again,” she said quietly.

Her friend sighed. “That is exactly why you should block him.”

It was not punishment or revenge. It was not meant to prove she was strong. It was for her. As long as his number remained in her phone, the door remained open. As long as she saw his picture, she could check. As long as she could visit his profile, she could search for signs. Had he posted? Was he with someone? Did he look happy? Did he miss her? Did his silence mean anything?

You can spend many weeks living somebody else's life instead of your own.

"But blocking feels so final," she said.

"You do not have to block him because you hate him."
Her friend placed a hand over hers. "Block him because you still love him."

The words hurt because they were true. It is easiest to block someone we no longer care about. It is harder when every message still moves something inside us; when part of us still hopes; when deep down we believe that what we longed for might yet happen.

That evening, she stared at his name. Her finger hovered over the screen. She reread their last conversation. Some messages were tender; others cold. There were promises that never became real, words that gave her hope, and long periods of silence.

She remembered all the nights she slept with the phone beside her pillow, all the mornings when checking for his message was the first thing she did, and all the times she tried to persuade herself that she no longer cared. One "How are you?" was enough for everything to begin again.

Then she pressed the button.

Nothing dramatic happened. No music played. She did not feel sudden happiness or stop loving him. It simply became quiet—and that silence was the hardest part.

The first day felt strange. The second was harder. On the third, she wanted to unblock him for a moment, just to look and make sure nothing had changed. Then she remembered her friend's words: "Do not reopen a wound every day to see whether it has healed."

She put down the phone and went for a walk—not to forget him, only to spend one hour without thinking about him constantly. That was the beginning of her journey, not toward forgetting, but toward reclaiming herself.

After several weeks, she noticed something small. One morning she woke and, for a few seconds, did not think of him. Only a few seconds, but to her it was enormous. Later came whole hours, then days when the memory appeared only occasionally.

She still missed him. She still wondered how he was. But she no longer had to know. Perhaps that mattered most.

Sometimes we confuse love with the need for information. We want to know where he is, who he is with, what he is doing, whether he thinks of us, whether he has someone, and whether he is happy. Knowing does not help us stop loving. Sometimes it merely prolongs the pain.

NOT EVERY BLOCK IS CHILDISH

Some people call blocking an overreaction: "Why block him? Just do not write." Perhaps that is enough for some. But not everyone has the same strength. If every appearance sends us back to the beginning, we have the right to set a boundary.

We may mute, delete the contact, unfollow, restrict access to his life, or sometimes block him—not to hurt him, but to stop hurting ourselves. We do not have to justify it.

After a few weeks, her friend asked, “Well?”

She smiled. “I still miss him.”
“So blocking did not help?”
She shook her head. “It did.”
“How?”

Looking out of the window, she said, “I did not stop loving him. But I stopped reminding myself every day why we cannot be together.”

Forgetting was not what she had imagined. You do not wake one day and suddenly feel nothing. You do not throw memories out of your mind. You do not stop remembering. One day, the memory simply loses its power over your day. You can think of him and still do what you need to do. You can miss him and not write. You can love him and not return. You can remember and keep moving forward.

Sometimes the hardest thing we can do for our heart is not to say, “I no longer love you,” because we may not be able to say that for a long time. Sometimes it is enough to say, “I love you, but I cannot live like this anymore,” and put down the phone. Close the door. Turn off notifications. Delete the picture. Block the number.

Not as revenge, but as the beginning of silence. In that silence, something we have been unable to do for so long may finally happen: we may hear ourselves.

After such returns, one question remains: who are you to him—a partner, a memory, or merely a possibility? The next

story is about one word that can hold a woman in place for years: “maybe.”

CHAPTER 8

I Do Not Want to Be Someone's "Maybe"



I Do Not Want to Be Someone's "Maybe"

"We'll see." "I don't know." "Things are good as they are." "I don't like labels."

For a long time, she thought these words meant, "Wait a little longer." Perhaps they simply meant, "I do not want what you want."

She did not want to pressure him, demand too much, or be "difficult," so she accepted less and less. One day she said, "I do not need a promise for life. I only need to know whether we are moving in the same direction."

He did not answer. His silence was the answer.

Not every connection must become a relationship, and not every love gets a happy ending. But we should not abandon

our needs because we fear losing the other person. Better to lose a relationship than yourself.

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When you dare to say, “I do not want to be someone’s maybe,” you stop waiting for another person’s decision. Then someone may remind you that you are still a woman—not merely the story of your disappointments. The next story begins with the gaze of a younger man.

CHAPTER 9

When a Younger Man Looked at Her



When a Younger Man Looked at Her

She was fifty. She no longer expected a younger man to look at her that way—not as an “older woman,” but as a woman: desirable, interesting, feminine.

Her femininity had not disappeared. She had simply stopped noticing it over the years.

He did not ask her age. He asked, “What do you enjoy? Where would you like to travel? What do you dream about?”

Suddenly, she remembered that for a long time she had been, above all, a mother, wife, and employee. Now she was herself again. A woman.

Such a relationship does not have to last forever, but it can still show us something: that we remain capable of emotion,

desire, fascination, and falling in love. Age does not take away a woman's right to live.

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We do not have to be younger to be attractive, look twenty, or prove that time has stopped. Maturity has its own strength. Femininity has no expiry date.

That gaze may be beautiful, but it brings questions about age, intentions, and self-worth. When a woman has her own money and an established life, another question appears: does someone love me—or what my life can give him?

CHAPTER 10

He Did Not Love Her Money. He Loved What It Gave Him



He Did Not Love Her Money. He Loved What It Gave Him

She was independent. She had her own company, apartment, and money. She did not need a man to support her. That was why it took her so long to notice that he needed her far more than she needed him.

At first, it was romantic. Then came the requests: “Can you lend me some?” “Will you pay?” “It makes no difference to you.”

One day she wondered, “Does he love me, or the life he can have beside me?”

Money is not proof of love. Neither is help. A healthy relationship may be a financial partnership, but it should not turn one person into the other’s sponsor. When money begins

to replace affection, it becomes difficult to know what was ever real.

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Money can cloud the picture. Sometimes we must allow ourselves not to know immediately whether someone is interested in us or in our opportunities. The next story is simpler: one coffee and no promises.

CHAPTER 11

One Coffee Is Not a Promise



One Coffee Is Not a Promise

She met him for coffee. Only coffee. They talked for two hours, laughed, and felt comfortable together. When she returned home, a friend asked, “So? Will anything come of it?”

She did not know—and, for the first time, did not need to know. Coffee was only coffee: a meeting between two people, not a declaration, the beginning of a relationship, or a promise.

In a world of fast connections, we assign meaning too quickly to everything: one message, one heart emoji, one meeting, one night. But we learn who a person is over time—not through pictures or declarations. Knowing someone requires presence.

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Not every conversation begins a love story. Not every flirtation is a promise. Not every coffee leads to a relationship. Let people be people before we turn them into our hopes.

One coffee may be only coffee, or it may begin the process of seeing someone without the filter of our hopes. Not every relationship immediately has a name. Sometimes it is only a moment that leaves a mark.

CHAPTER 12

A Brief Relationship That Stayed in Her Heart



A Brief Relationship That Stayed in Her Heart

She did not plan to fall in love. Neither did he. They met mostly in hotels and apartments. Sometimes he travelled; sometimes she did. Later came limits: fewer messages, fewer conversations, flirtatious texts, and then silence. That silence hurt most.

He had given her something missing from her life for a long time: tenderness, beautiful words, interest, closeness, emotion. For a while, she felt special. That was why forgetting was so difficult. Sometimes we do not miss only the person. We miss how we felt beside him.

She pretended everything was fine and that she did not care, while inside she suffered. The worst part was watching him give another woman exactly what he had once given her: the

same words, the same flirtation, the same look—except now he no longer looked at her.

Then she understood: a beautiful moment is not always the beginning of a beautiful relationship. Sometimes it is only a moment. Yet some moments remain within us far longer than they should.

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After stories like these, it is easy to think every intimacy should become a relationship. It need not. Sometimes someone gives us something important but cannot give us everything we need. That is where the next part of this book begins.



PART III WOMAN AND MAN

Perhaps this is where we should stop asking, “Who is right?” and begin asking, “What is the other person truly trying to say?” A woman and a man often stand on the same side but cannot see it.

CHAPTER 13

The Man Who Could Not Talk About Feelings



The Man Who Could Not Talk About Feelings

He did not say, "I'm afraid." He said, "I need some time."

He did not say, "I'm hurting." He said, "Everything's okay."

He did not say, "I need you." He simply sat beside her.

For years, he had been taught that a man must be strong, solve problems, never complain, and never show weakness. But a person who has not learned to speak about emotions does not stop having them. He simply does not know how to show them.

For a long time, she believed his silence meant indifference. One day she asked, “What are you afraid of?”

After a long silence, he answered, “That I won’t be enough for you.”

It was the first sentence that truly brought them closer.

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We should not excuse disrespect because of gender. But neither should we assume that silence always means an absence of feeling. A man may feel deeply and not know how to name it. A woman may feel deeply and talk about it for hours. Both need to learn the other person’s language.

Perhaps we should stop asking who is right. A woman may need conversation while a man needs silence. The next chapter views the same relationship from both sides—where each is partly right and partly wrong.

CHAPTER 14

She Wanted Closeness; He Wanted Peace



She Wanted Closeness; He Wanted Peace

She wanted to talk in the evening. He wanted to rest.

“What do you feel?” she asked.

“I don’t know,” he answered.

She heard rejection. He heard pressure. Yet both needed safety; each simply understood it differently.

One evening she said, “I do not want to attack you. I want to understand you.”

He replied, “And I do not want to run away. I just need you to give me a moment.”

That was the beginning of change—not because they suddenly became perfect, but because they stopped fighting over who was right.

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When we begin to see the other person's needs, a harder question emerges: what if we are both right? A relationship is not a contest someone must win.

CHAPTER 15

They Were Both Right, and Both Wrong



They Were Both Right, and Both Wrong

She had the right to want conversation. He had the right to need a moment of silence. She had the right to feel. He had the right not to know immediately what he felt.

The problem began only when each decided that their own need mattered more than the other's.

A relationship is not a competition. The point is not to win the argument. Sometimes you can be right and still lose a person. Or you can say, "I understand that you see it differently," and stay—not in order to agree, but to understand.

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When we stop fighting to be right, we can finally talk about what we truly need—not what is expected or what the other person is supposed to guess. The next chapter is about needs.

CHAPTER 16

Tell Me What You Truly Need



Tell Me What You Truly Need

“What do you need?”

The question felt harder than all the others. For years, she had said, “It doesn’t matter,” “Whatever you want,” “That’s fine,” and “I don’t need anything.” Then she felt resentment because nobody gave her what she needed.

At last, she said, “I need tenderness. I need you to write first sometimes. I need to know that I matter to you. I also need physical intimacy.”

She was unsure how he would react. He simply answered, “I’m glad you told me.”

Talking about needs does not destroy intimacy; it builds it. This includes sex, touch, tenderness, how often we meet, security, fidelity, boundaries, and everything that may seem obvious to one person but not to another. There is no shame in saying, “This is what I need.”

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Do not expect someone else to guess how often you want to meet. Do not assume they know what fidelity means to you, understand your sexual needs, or know what you fear in a relationship. Talk. It may be harder than silence, but it is far more honest.

Speaking about needs may bring us closer, but it may also reveal differences. When we stop guessing, we begin to hear the truth. Sometimes the truth leads to understanding; sometimes it reveals that two people now stand on opposite sides of the same relationship.

CHAPTER 17

When We Stopped Being Partners and Became Opponents



When We Stopped Being Partners and Became Opponents

At first, they fought over small things. Then over everything: who did more, who sacrificed more, who hurt the other first, and who should apologise.

One day, they realised they had stopped fighting for the relationship and begun fighting each other.

When one person hurts, the other is not automatically to blame. When a woman says, “I feel awful,” she does not always mean, “It is your fault.” When a man says, “I need space,” he does not always mean, “I do not want you.”

Sometimes we should stop listening only to the words and ask, “What are you truly trying to tell me?”

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When partners become opponents, every conversation can feel like a battle. Who is right? Who should apologise? The next story interrupts that spiral and asks: are we still truly listening to one another?

CHAPTER 18

Do We Truly Listen to One Another?



Do We Truly Listen to One Another?

Listening is not waiting for your turn. It is not preparing your answer or proving that the other person is wrong. Listening begins when we genuinely want to know, “What is happening inside you?”

One evening she said, “I do not want you to fix it.”

“Then what do you want?”

“I want you to listen to me.”

He sat beside her. He did not interrupt or offer advice. He was simply there. When she finished, he said, “Now I understand.”

Perhaps it did not solve the problem, but it changed something more important: she was no longer alone with it.

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When you stop fighting to make someone admit you are right, you begin to hear something more important—yourself. Sometimes that is the beginning of reclaiming a life beyond the relationship. From here, we move to the end of one life and the beginning of the next.



Sometimes only when a relationship ends do we understand how completely we forgot ourselves. Sometimes we must pass through loneliness to stop fearing it. Sometimes we must lose someone in order to find ourselves.

CHAPTER 19

Divorce Was Not the End



Divorce Was Not the End

When something ends, we do not have to know immediately what comes next. We only have to avoid remaining forever inside what is already over.

Today I know that divorce was not the end of my life. It was the end of one way of living. The difference between those sentences is enormous.

A person can fall apart and rebuild differently—sometimes even better. I do not want to display every wound. A wound does not have to be shown to be real. But I want to say this: you can survive very difficult experiences without losing the ability to love, dream, and begin again.

Over time, I began to see my past differently—not as evidence that I had failed, but as part of the story that shaped me.

It was not easy. There were days when I wanted to put everything down and say, "I have no strength left." Those were the days that taught me a new beginning does not always look like great courage. Sometimes it looks like getting up in the morning and taking the one necessary step.

Later came education, further studies, and new plans. Each step rebuilt something in me that had seemed lost.

You can be a mother and still be a woman. You can be responsible and still have dreams. You can be strong and still say, "I need help."

One of the most important lessons after divorce was that you cannot build your whole life around making other people feel comfortable. For years, I could be everything for others and leave myself in last place.

So I began with simple things: work, learning, responsibilities that could not wait, people who stayed near, and small decisions that did not look like great beginnings but gradually became exactly that. I did not have every answer. I only had the next day to live.

First came fear. What now? What would my life look like? Would I manage? Would the children be all right? Would I ever trust someone again? And perhaps hardest of all: could I trust myself?

The end of one story did not mean the end of the woman who lived through it. For a long time, I had thought divorce would close the door not only on one relationship, but also on the part of me built around family, duties, and a shared life. It did not.

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Divorce can close one life, but it does not have to close the woman. When the first pain grows quieter, a question appears: will I forever be only the woman defined by what happened to me? The next chapter asks who we are when we stop defining ourselves by our wounds.

CHAPTER 20

I Am Not What Happened to Me



I Am Not What Happened to Me

Perhaps true self-recovery begins when you stop asking who you were to someone else and begin asking who you want to be for yourself.

The past is part of me, but it does not own my future. Choosing badly once does not mean every future choice will be wrong. Trusting someone and being hurt does not mean I must never trust again. One relationship ending does not mean love has ended.

I discovered that we can accept our story without allowing it to write the ending for us. I no longer have to pretend I fear nothing or make myself indestructible.

My sense of humour. My curiosity. My need to grow. My dreams. My sensitivity. My strength—and also my weaknesses. I remained.

At first, the answer was difficult, but slowly I began to know it. One day I asked: what remains of me if I remove every role—mother, employee, student, partner, divorced woman, woman after difficult experiences?

There is a difference between being what happened to us and being the person who decides what to do next. I am a woman who passed through all of it. I am not divorce. I am not betrayal. I am not the man who left. I am not the woman someone chose—or did not choose. None of those things is my name.

Divorce, mistakes, bad decisions, disappointments, relationships that did not become what they were meant to be, loneliness—all can become labels when we spend too long looking backward. For a while, I saw myself only through what had happened to me.

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If we are not what happened to us, we must begin building an answer to who we are today. Then comes the moment when a woman stops waiting for someone else to begin her life for her.

CHAPTER 21

The Woman Who Stopped Waiting



The Woman Who Stopped Waiting

Perhaps the question should not be, “When will he come back?” but “What do I want to do with the day I have today?”

Your life may not yet look as you imagined, but it is still yours. You do not have to wait for someone to begin it. It has already begun.

That was an enormous change. When you no longer need someone else in order to feel alive, you can finally choose a person not from fear, but from desire.

She still dreamed of love. She wanted closeness and someone with whom to share ordinary days. But love was no longer a condition for happiness. She stopped checking whether she

was good enough for him and began checking whether he was good enough for her.

She started going out, travelling, meeting people, learning, laughing, and doing things simply because she wanted to. First for an hour, then an entire evening. Later, she planned days with no room for waiting.

She put down the phone. She understood that her life could not be a waiting room for somebody else's decision.

Hope can be beautiful, but it can also hold a person still for years. Waiting had thousands of forms: checking the phone, visiting his profile, analysing one word, or imagining a conversation that never happened. She waited for a call, a message, an apology, his decision, and the moment when he would finally understand.

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When you stop waiting, you reclaim time. But reclaimed time must be filled with your own life. This leads to the next lesson: you can love deeply without losing yourself.

CHAPTER 22

You Can Love Without Losing Yourself



You Can Love Without Losing Yourself

It is worth asking: beside him, does my life become larger—or smaller?

You do not have to choose between being loved and being yourself. In a good relationship, both can exist together. Love should create closeness, but it should not take away identity.

A relationship needs room for two people: his world and yours, his needs and yours, his friends and yours, shared plans and separate moments. When one person becomes the only centre and the other merely revolves around them, exhaustion eventually comes.

A boundary does not say, “I do not need you.” It says, “I need you, but I will not give you all of myself.” That is not

selfishness. You can love deeply and still remember: I matter too.

A healthy relationship does not demand that you stop seeing friends, abandon your interests, or remain constantly available. It does not ask you to disappear.

I now know that a person can give so much that one day she no longer recognises her own life. For years, I confused sacrifice with love. I believed that the more I surrendered, the stronger the relationship would become.

You can love and need a few hours alone. You can love and want to go out by yourself. You can love and keep things that belong only to you. You can love and say no. You can love and have your own friends, money, dreams, and time. Love should not mean giving up your own life.

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Love without a self begins to resemble disappearance. When you learn to stay yourself inside a relationship, the next step appears: you stop proving that you deserve love.

CHAPTER 23

I No Longer Have to Prove Anything



I No Longer Have to Prove Anything

Once you understand this, the future looks completely different.

You only need to stop persuading the wrong person that you are worthy of what you need from him. You do not have to convince the right person that you are worth loving.

The questions that reveal whether we know our worth are these: can I say what I need? Can I refuse? Can I leave when I am treated badly? Can I be myself without constantly wondering whether someone will like me for it?

Today another question matters more to me: do I choose myself within this relationship?

My value does not begin when someone chooses me. It was already within me. His choice speaks about him—his needs, readiness, and life. It does not set my price.

If someone leaves for another woman, it does not mean she is better. It means only that he made his decision. I am not a competition or a product on a shelf. I do not have to be better than another woman in order to have worth.

Love gained at the cost of yourself is too expensive. For years, I believed value was something I had to earn: if I became more patient, attractive, understanding, less demanding, sexier, or more available, someone would finally choose me for good.

I do not have to be constantly available or perfect. I do not have to be the woman beside whom life is never difficult. I do not have to be the most beautiful or the youngest. I do not have to compete with another woman or keep a man at any price. I no longer have to prove anything to anyone.

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When you stop proving your worth, the future stops being a question of who will choose you. It becomes a question of what you still want to experience. The next chapter is about possibility—the idea that your most beautiful chapter may still be ahead.

CHAPTER 24

My Most Beautiful Chapter Is Still Ahead



My Most Beautiful Chapter Is Still Ahead

When you close this book, I do not want your only thought to be, “I have been through so much.” I want you to think, “There is still so much ahead of me.”

It may begin very quietly—with the decision that you will no longer postpone yourself. The most beautiful chapter need not be the first or the one you are living now. It may be the next.

A woman with a difficult past knows the loneliness of living beside someone. She knows the pain of betrayal, rejection, and uncertainty. Precisely for that reason, she can choose differently. A woman who has been through things is not a woman without a future. Often, she is a woman who finally knows what she no longer wants.

One day, you may look in the mirror and see all the years behind you. Instead of asking, “What have I lost?” you can ask, “What can I still experience?” That question does not change the past, but it changes the way you look at the future.

You do not have to know what will happen in ten years or have a complete plan. The next step is enough. One morning, you may simply wake and say, “I want to live differently.”

You can begin studying, change jobs, open a business, move away, learn a language, meet new people, fall in love, end a relationship that harms you, or begin again.

The culture around us too easily gives women an expiry date, as though after a certain age they should merely “live quietly” rather than begin new stories. But who said the best must happen early?

Perhaps you are afraid your best years are behind you. Perhaps you are thirty, fifty, or sixty. Perhaps you have just ended a marriage, been alone for years, or fallen in love with someone unable to love you in the way you needed.

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At this point, I do not want to leave you with another instruction. I want to leave you with a question. After all these stories about love, loss, boundaries, loneliness, and choices—what does your heart truly want? We will answer that in the epilogue.

EPILOGUE

Tell Me What Your Heart Feels

At the end of this book, I do not want to give you a list of rules. I do not want to tell you how to love or what kind of man to choose. I only want to ask one thing:

What does your heart truly feel?

Not what your family expects. Not what society expects. Not what is considered proper. Not what a man wants. Not what you are afraid to say.

You.

What do you need? Closeness? Peace? Touch? Conversation? Safety? Or, above all, do you need to feel like yourself again?

We are not perfect. Neither are men. Women sometimes talk too much. Men sometimes talk too little. Women sometimes expect others to read their minds. Men sometimes retreat into silence. Both make mistakes.

But perhaps we no longer have to be opponents. Perhaps we can sit on the same side of the table and say, "Tell me what you need," then truly listen to the answer.

Maybe that is what we lack most—not perfect women, perfect men, or more advice, but people able to say: "I am afraid." "I need you." "I do not understand, but I want to." "I hurt you." "I am sorry." "Stay."

And sometimes: "Go. You deserve something better."

If you remember only one sentence from this book, let it be this:

CONCLUSION

You do not have to be easy to love.

You have to be real.

If you ever again feel that you are “too difficult,” pause. Perhaps you are not difficult. Perhaps, for the first time in your life, you are saying aloud what you need.

Maybe that is where real love begins—not the fairy-tale kind, but the real kind: imperfect, sometimes difficult, yet full of conversation, intimacy, respect, and choice.

In the end, we do not need a prince or a princess. We need a human being. And we can be that human being too—for ourselves, for another person, and for the love no one taught us before.

For the love no one taught us before.